

Reunification Viability in Divided Nations: A Conceptual Causal Model and the Case of Divided Azerbaijan

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Abstract:

Reunification in divided societies is often framed as a matter of shared identity or geopolitical opportunity. This article argues that such single-factor explanations are insufficient. It develops a conceptual causal model that defines reunification viability as a conjunctural configuration requiring simultaneous alignment across three dimensions: societal desire, integration feasibility, and external geopolitical permissiveness. The model is named Reunification Viability Model (RVM) and distinguishes structural drivers (such as institutional divergence, economic asymmetry, and cross-border interaction) from a mediating mechanism of perceived net benefit. The model is applied qualitatively to the case of divided Azerbaijan to assess how structural conditions map onto these dimensions. The analysis suggests that symbolic affinity alone does not generate viability where institutional complexity, fiscal considerations, and restrictive external conditions constrain alignment. The article offers a transferable analytical framework for evaluating territorial reunification in divided societies. The causal model is diagnostic rather than deterministically predictive: it specifies configurational conditions under which viability is possible rather than forecasting specific political outcomes, consistent with a necessary-condition logic of conjunctural causation.

Keywords: Reunification Viability, Conjunctural Causation, Geopolitical Opportunity Structure, Ethnonational Identity, State Capacity, Political Economy of Integration, Azerbaijan

1 INTRODUCTION

Political reunification in divided societies is rarely determined by identity alone. Long-term separation under distinct state systems reshapes institutions, economic structures, and social norms in ways that may either preserve symbolic affinity or generate structural divergence. In such contexts, the question is not simply whether a shared ethnolinguistic identity persists, but under what conditions political reintegration becomes socially desirable, institutionally feasible, and geopolitically possible. Comparative experience demonstrates that even where cultural continuity remains strong, material and institutional constraints significantly shape reunification debates (Alesina and Spolaore, 2005; O'Leary, 2022).

The case of divided Azerbaijan presents a particularly complex configuration. Approximately two centuries of political separation under different state systems have produced divergent institutional trajectories. In the north, prolonged secular governance under the Russian Empire and the Soviet Union followed by post-1991 state consolidation fostered a largely secular public sphere and a sovereign institutional framework. In the south, integration within the Islamic Republic of Iran embedded religious governance structures more centrally within public and political life. These divergent institutional logics extend beyond religion to encompass economic organization, administrative culture, legal norms, and political authority structures.

Economic asymmetry further complicates the picture. Resource endowments, fiscal capacity, and perceived redistribution burdens influence how populations and political elites evaluate potential integration. Comparative debates in Ireland illustrate how reunification discussions often shift from identity-based arguments to fiscal and administrative calculations, particularly when structural deficits or redistribution costs are involved (O'Leary, 2022). Political economy research similarly demonstrates that territorial integration decisions are shaped by expectations of economic benefit or cost, not by cultural affinity alone (Alesina and Spolaore, 2005).

The single-factor explanations this paper challenges are not strawmen. A significant strand of the comparative literature prioritizes shared identity as the primary driver of territorial unification. Realist-influenced accounts similarly foreground geopolitical opportunity as the decisive factor, treating domestic preferences as secondary (Mearsheimer, 2001). While this

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paper does not dismiss either factor, it argues—alongside Roeder (2007, 2018)—that neither identity nor geopolitical opportunity suffices as a standalone explanation. Roeder’s work on segment states demonstrates that ethnic solidarity organized around institutionalized “segment states” does not automatically generate successful unification nationalism, because political entrepreneurs face structural barriers that identity alone cannot overcome. The present model builds on this insight by specifying the full configurational structure under which reunification viability can be objectively and analytically assessed, extending Roeder’s institutional logic to include bilateral economic perception, state capacity, and external gating conditions.

This paper argues that reunification viability must be understood as the interaction of three analytically distinct but interdependent dimensions:

- Societal desire – the degree of public support for integration, shaped by identity, perceived compatibility, and expected outcomes.
- Political feasibility – the institutional and fiscal capacity to absorb structural change.
- Geopolitical opportunity – the external and regional conditions that permit or constrain transformation.

Rather than forecasting specific political outcomes, the study develops a diagnostic causal model that maps how structural variables influence the above three dimensions. The model operates within a necessary-condition logic: it specifies configurational thresholds below which viability cannot emerge, without asserting that meeting those thresholds would deterministically lead to reunification. This diagnostic framing differs from purely descriptive accounts and from probabilistic predictive models. The model distinguishes between emotionally expressed preferences and operationally grounded support, and it treats cost-benefit perception as bilateral and simultaneous. Reunification becomes viable only when expected net benefits are perceived to be positive on both sides and when geopolitical constraints allow change.

The paper addresses the following research questions:

- RQ1: What structural variables shape societal desire for reunification in divided Azerbaijan?
- RQ2: What factors determine the political and institutional feasibility of reunification?
- RQ3: How do bilateral cost-benefit perceptions and geopolitical constraints interact to determine overall reunification viability?

By proposing an integrated systems-based causal framework, this study contributes to the comparative analysis of divided societies and offers a structured method for evaluating reunification conditions without resorting to normative or predictive claims.

The question of reunification in the Azerbaijani context cannot be separated from broader regional security dynamics in the South Caucasus. The region remains characterized by contested sovereignties, unresolved territorial disputes, and shifting power alignments involving Russia, Türkiye, and Iran. Iran–Azerbaijan relations in particular have experienced periodic tension shaped by security concerns, cross-border identity politics, and geopolitical signaling. In this environment, territorial questions are embedded within a complex border politics landscape in which sovereignty norms, regional rivalries, and security sensitivities structure the range of politically feasible outcomes. Situating reunification within this regional configuration underscores the importance of analyzing viability not as an abstract nationalist aspiration, but as a border-embedded structural problem.

2 BACKGROUND AND RELATED WORK

2.1 REUNIFICATION IN DIVIDED SOCIETIES

Territorial reunification has most often been examined in cases where a historically continuous ethnonational community was politically divided and subsequently developed under distinct state systems. The German and Irish cases provide two analytically contrasting trajectories.

German reunification in 1990 illustrates how rapid political integration is possible when three conditions align: (1) strong ethnolinguistic continuity, (2) institutional absorption capacity of one state, and (3) permissive geopolitical alignment among major powers. Although the Federal Republic and the German Democratic Republic diverged for four decades under competing ideological regimes, a shared national identity remained salient across both societies (Chafetz et al., 2012). However, reunification imposed significant fiscal and institutional adjustment costs, including asymmetric development, transfer dependency, and long-term productivity gaps (Livingston, 1992). The German case therefore demonstrates that identity alignment alone does not eliminate structural integration costs.

Ireland presents a different trajectory. Despite strong cultural, linguistic, and historical commonalities across the island, political partition after 1921 produced durable institutional and identity divergence. The Northern Ireland conflict was not primarily about ethnic difference but about competing constitutional preferences and state loyalties within a shared historical community (Coakley, 2007). The 1998 Good Friday Agreement did not create reunification but instead institutionalized power-sharing under a conditional constitutional framework (O'leary, 2005). The Irish case shows that even where cultural continuity persists, prolonged institutional separation can entrench differentiated political identities and render reunification contingent on constitutional, demographic, and geopolitical shifts.

Together, these cases suggest that reunification feasibility depends on more than shared identity. It requires institutional compatibility, fiscal absorption capacity, elite alignment, and an enabling external environment. Where these structural conditions are absent, reunification may remain symbolically salient yet politically constrained.

2.2 IDENTITY VS STRUCTURAL CONSTRAINT

National identity is frequently invoked as the primary driver of territorial unity. However, modern nationalism scholarship emphasizes that identity is neither static nor determinative (Anderson, 2006; Brubaker, 2004). States actively construct and reshape identity through education, media, and institutional incentives (Gellner, 1983).

Recent scholarship on divided societies highlights that identity salience fluctuates depending on institutional context and opportunity structures (Cederman et al., 2010). Structural constraints — including regime type, elite incentives, economic interdependence, and security alignments — often outweigh affective identity in determining political outcomes (Fearon and Laitin, 2003).

In many divided nations, long-term separation produces differentiated institutional identities even when ethnolinguistic continuity remains intact (Linz and Stepan, 1996). Identity divergence may therefore become endogenous to institutional environments, complicating assumptions that shared ethnicity naturally leads to political reunification.

2.3 POLITICAL ECONOMY OF TERRITORIAL INTEGRATION

Beyond questions of identity, territorial integration generates substantial fiscal, institutional, and distributive consequences. The political economy literature emphasizes that reunification is rarely cost-neutral; it involves asymmetric development, redistribution, and long-term structural adjustment (Alesina and Spolaore, 2005).

The German case remains the most studied modern example of rapid territorial absorption. Following reunification in 1990, large-scale fiscal transfers from West to East Germany were implemented through solidarity surcharges, infrastructure investment, and social welfare equalization. Estimates suggest cumulative transfers exceeding one trillion euros over three decades (Sinn, 2002). While monetary and legal integration occurred quickly, productivity convergence proved slower and uneven. East Germany experienced persistent wage gaps, employment dislocation, and demographic outflows (Burda, 2006). Scholars have noted that political unification did not eliminate structural disparities; instead, it institutionalized long-term fiscal redistribution (Sinn, 2002). The German experience thus demonstrates that strong national identity does not substitute for economic convergence and that fiscal absorption capacity is central to integration stability.

In the Irish context, reunification has not occurred, yet extensive economic modeling has examined its potential implications. (Bergin et al., 2025a) evaluates the fiscal costs of Irish unity, highlighting significant public expenditure harmonization challenges between Northern Ireland and the Republic of Ireland. Similarly, the ESRI (Economic and Social Research Institute) has modeled trade, labor market, and fiscal adjustment scenarios under various constitutional outcomes (Bergin et al., 2025b). Studies emphasize the importance of subsidy replacement, tax regime alignment, and welfare system integration, particularly given Northern Ireland's current fiscal subvention from the United Kingdom (Doyle, 2021). The literature consistently finds that reunification would require careful transitional arrangements to avoid economic shock.

These cases illustrate that territorial integration is fundamentally a distributive project. It requires resolving three core economic questions: (1) how fiscal transfers are financed, (2) how institutional systems are harmonized, and (3) how asymmetric productivity levels are managed. Reunification without credible economic planning risks destabilizing both absorbing and integrated regions.

Accordingly, any assessment of reunification feasibility must incorporate not only symbolic and identity dimensions but also fiscal sustainability, institutional harmonization, and long-term convergence trajectories.

2.4 GAPS IN THE LITERATURE AND CONTRIBUTIONS OF THIS WORK

The existing literature on territorial reunification falls into two broad categories. First, historical and ex post analyses examine completed cases such as German unification, focusing on fiscal transfers, institutional absorption, and long-term convergence dynamics. Second, forward-looking economic studies – such as those modeling potential Irish reunification – evaluate fiscal costs, subsidy replacement, and institutional harmonization under specific policy scenarios.

While these strands provide valuable empirical and policy insight, they remain largely case-specific and descriptive. The comparative politics literature on reunification, secession, and irredentism has long acknowledged that territorial outcomes are multi-determined. Roeder (2007, 2018) provides theoretically rigorous accounts of “segment states” and “unification nationalism,” demonstrating that ethnic solidarity does not straightforwardly produce political integration. The broader literature on divided societies – encompassing the German, Irish, Korean, and Cypriot cases – similarly emphasizes the interplay of identity, institutional structure, and external constraint (Linz and Stepan, 1996; Alesina and Spolaore, 2005). This study does not claim to be the first to recognize multi-dimensionality in reunification dynamics.

This study contributes by developing a synthetic conjunctural framework specifically calibrated for divided societies characterized by asymmetric sovereignty, pronounced institutional divergence, and constrained external geopolitical environments. Such cases – in which one side lacks sovereignty while the other operates as a consolidating state, and in which regional powers exercise potential veto authority – pose distinctive analytical challenges that existing models address only partially. The framework developed here is tailored to this configuration and is explicitly comparative in design, enabling systematic application across analogous cases. Research Design and Approach

This study adopts a conceptual causal modeling approach to analyze the conditions under which reunification may become viable in divided Azerbaijan. This approach is appropriate because the phenomenon under examination is multi-dimensional, structurally embedded, and contingent on interacting political, economic, institutional, and geopolitical variables. Reunification viability cannot be reduced to a single measurable indicator; rather, it emerges from the configuration of multiple interdependent determinants. A structured conceptual model allows these interactions to be clarified without prematurely imposing statistical assumptions.

Causal explanation occupies a central place in political science. While much contemporary work operationalizes causality through statistical estimation and formal inference (Blackwell, 2013; Braumoeller et al., 2018), comparative political analysis has long emphasized mechanism-based and context-sensitive approaches (Falleti and Lynch, 2009). These approaches focus on identifying how structural conditions interact to generate political outcomes, particularly in cases where controlled experimentation or large-N statistical testing is not feasible. The present study builds on this tradition by constructing an explanatory framework that maps directional relationships among key determinants of reunification viability.

The analytical strategy proceeds in three stages. First, structural determinants are identified through engagement with scholarship on divided societies, political economy, institutional divergence, and state capacity. Second, these determinants are organized into an internally coherent explanatory structure linking them to clearly defined outcome dimensions. Third, the framework is applied qualitatively to the Azerbaijani case to assess how specific configurations of structural conditions influence reunification viability. The first two stages are developed in Section 4, where the conceptual causal model is specified, while the third stage is undertaken in Section 5 through application to the Azerbaijani case.

In applying the framework to the Azerbaijani case, the analysis relies primarily on published scholarship and documented secondary sources. In addition, it benefits from the author’s long-term academic engagement across both polities. This positional familiarity is used interpretively – to contextualize patterns identified in the literature and to assess plausibility – rather than as standalone empirical evidence. All evaluative claims remain grounded in publicly available research.

The scope of the study is conceptual and diagnostic rather than deterministically predictive or normative. It does not estimate probabilities, forecast political change, or advocate a particular outcome. Consistent with a necessary-condition logic of conjunctural causation, it specifies the structural configurations that make reunification possible rather than predicting when or whether it will occur. Instead, it offers a structured analytical tool for examining how interacting structural factors shape the viability of reunification in divided societies.

3 THE CONCEPTUAL CAUSAL MODEL: REUNIFICATION VIABILITY MODEL (RVM)

We have designed and present in Figure 1 a general conceptual causal model of reunification viability in divided societies. The model identifies structural determinants, mediating mechanisms, and outcome dimensions that jointly shape whether political reunification becomes viable. Reunification is not treated as a binary or identity-driven outcome, but as a conditional possibility emerging from the interaction of domestic alignment and external opportunity structures.

The model is organized into four analytical layers: (1) structural drivers, (2) mediating perceptions of net benefit, (3) domestic outcome dimensions, and (4) external geopolitical opportunity conditions.

These four layers are related by a directional causal logic: structural drivers (Layer 1) operate as exogenous inputs that shape perceived net benefit (Layer 2); perceived net benefit in turn mediates the domestic outcome dimensions of societal desire and integration feasibility (Layer 3) rather than constituting them directly; and the external geopolitical conditions (Layer 4) function as gating conditions that determine whether domestically aligned outcomes can translate into political transformation. Clarity on this sequencing resolves a potential ambiguity: perceived net benefit influences societal desire but is analytically prior to it and distinct from it.

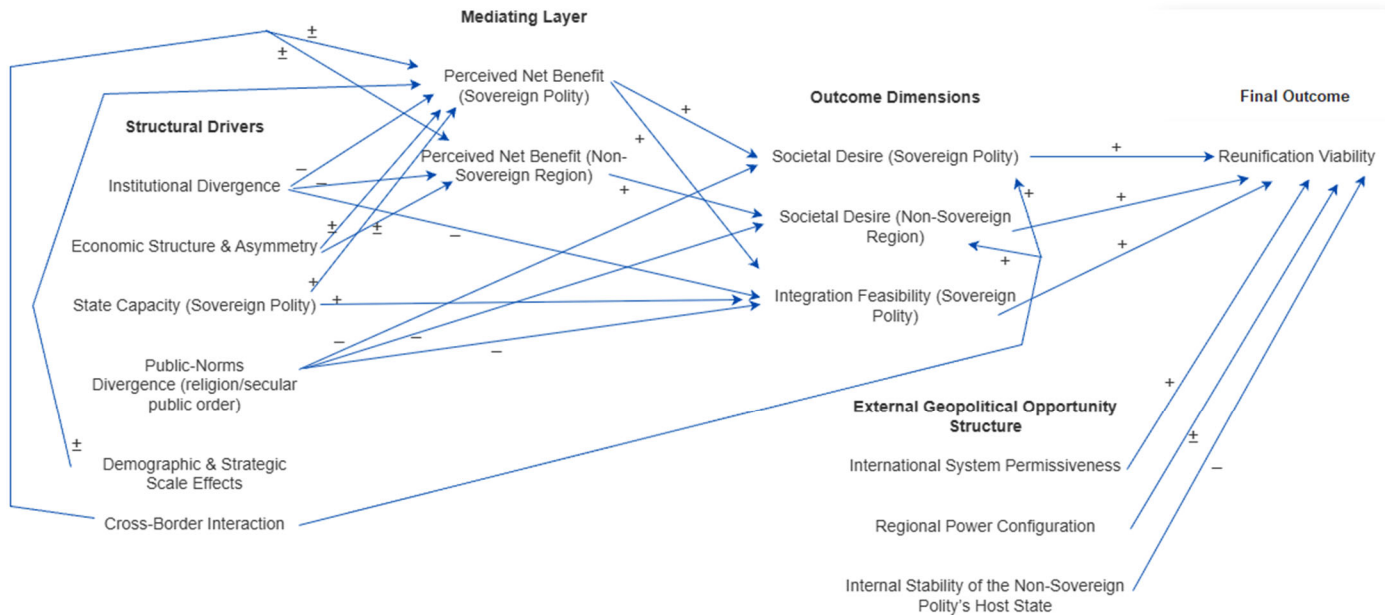


Figure 1-Conceptual Causal Structure of Reunification Viability, the Reunification Viability Model (RVM). Arrows represent unidirectional causal influence. The absence of a direct arrow between two variables constitutes an explicit claim of no direct causal relationship between them. Structural drivers (Layer 1) influence perceived net benefit (Layer 2) only; perceived net benefit mediates the domestic outcome dimensions (Layer 3); external geopolitical conditions (Layer 4) gate the translation of domestic alignment into political transformation and receive no arrows from domestic layers.

3.1 STRUCTURAL DRIVERS

The first layer consists of domestic structural determinants that shape perceptions and feasibility conditions.

Institutional Divergence refers to differences in formal governance structures, legal systems, administrative cultures, and policy frameworks that emerge through prolonged political separation. Greater institutional divergence increases anticipated integration complexity and adjustment costs, thereby reducing perceived net benefits and integration feasibility.

Economic Structure and Asymmetry captures differences in fiscal capacity, development level, resource endowments, and economic organization. Its effects are context-dependent. Where integration implies fiscal transfers or structural disruption, perceived net benefit declines; where complementarities or economic accretion are expected, perceived net benefit may increase.

State Capacity (Sovereign Polity) denotes the administrative, fiscal, and organizational capability of the sovereign state to implement large-scale institutional change. Higher state capacity enhances integration feasibility and may increase perceived net benefit by reducing anticipated transition risk.

Public-Norms Divergence (religious/secular public order) refers to divergence in the normative foundations of public life, including the role of religion, legitimacy structures, and societal expectations of governance. Normative divergence directly constrains societal desire and reduces integration feasibility by increasing perceived incompatibility.

Demographic and Strategic Scale Effects reflect both the potential fiscal burden of population absorption and the possible strategic advantages of increased population and territorial scale. Larger unified scale may increase redistribution costs

(negative effect) but may also enhance aggregate state power and international standing (positive effect). The net effect operates through perceived net benefit in the sovereign polity.

Cross-Border Interaction includes economic exchange, mobility, communication, and social ties across the divide. Greater interaction generally strengthens societal desire by increasing familiarity and reducing psychological distance. Its effect on perceived net benefit may vary depending on whether revealed complementarities or revealed incompatibilities dominate.

These structural drivers do not determine reunification directly. Instead, they operate primarily through a mediating mechanism: perceived net benefit.

3.2 MEDIATING MECHANISM: PERCEIVED NET BENEFIT

At the center of the model lies a bilateral evaluative mechanism: Perceived Net Benefit, specified separately for the sovereign polity and the non-sovereign region.

Perceived net benefit reflects an aggregate assessment of expected economic, institutional, and strategic consequences of reunification. It is not limited to fiscal considerations but includes anticipated risk, administrative burden, power gains, and uncertainty reduction.

Structural drivers influence perceived net benefit in both directions. Institutional divergence and demographic burden tend to reduce perceived benefit, while state capacity and strategic scale effects may increase it. Economic asymmetry and cross-border interaction operate conditionally. Perceived net benefit then influences two outcome dimensions: (1) Societal Desire in each polity; and (2) Integration Feasibility in the sovereign polity. This structure ensures that desire is not reducible to identity alone, and feasibility is not reducible to administrative capacity alone.

3.3 DOMESTIC OUTCOME DIMENSIONS

The model distinguishes three domestic outcome dimensions.

- **Societal Desire (Sovereign Polity)** represents the degree of public support for reunification within the sovereign state. It is shaped by perceived net benefit, public-norm divergence, and cross-border interaction. This dimension captures demand-side disposition only. It explicitly excludes assessments of institutional capacity or external permissiveness — a population may desire an outcome it recognises as currently infeasible or geopolitically blocked.
- **Societal Desire (Non-Sovereign Region)** captures public support within the region under alternative sovereignty. It is influenced by perceived net benefit, public-norm divergence, and cross-border interaction. As with the sovereign polity, this dimension is demand-side only. It does not incorporate judgements about the sovereign state's administrative capacity or the external geopolitical environment.
- **Integration Feasibility (Sovereign Polity)** refers to the political and institutional capacity to implement reunification in a sustainable manner. It is shaped by state capacity, institutional divergence, public-norm divergence, and perceived net benefit in the sovereign polity. This dimension is supply-side only. It explicitly excludes public preferences and geopolitical conditions — a state may have the administrative and fiscal capacity to implement reunification regardless of whether its population currently demands it or whether external conditions permit it.

Table 1-Analytical Boundaries of RVM Dimensions: Inclusions and Exclusions

Dimension	Layer	What it includes	What it explicitly excludes
Societal Desire (Sovereign Polity)	3	Public support for reunification; identity salience; cost-benefit disposition	Institutional capacity; geopolitical conditions
Societal Desire (Non-Sovereign Region)	3	Public support within non-sovereign region; identity resonance; governance preference	Sovereign state capacity; external constraints
Integration Feasibility (Sovereign Polity)	3	Administrative capacity; fiscal absorption; legal harmonization capability	Public preferences on either side; geopolitical environment
Perceived Net Benefit	2	Bilateral cost-benefit assessment mediating structural inputs into outcome dimensions	Not an outcome dimension — analytically prior to and distinct from societal desire
Geopolitical Permissiveness	4	Regional power stance; international norms; host-state internal stability	Domestic alignment conditions on either side

Reunification viability requires alignment across both societal desire dimensions and integration feasibility. High public support without feasibility is insufficient; and feasibility without societal support is politically unstable.

Table 1 summarizes the analytical boundaries of each model dimension, specifying both what each dimension includes and what it explicitly excludes. This boundary specification is necessary to prevent conceptual overlap and to ensure that each dimension contributes distinct analytical content to the overall configurational assessment.

3.4 EXTERNAL GEOPOLITICAL OPPORTUNITY STRUCTURE

Even when domestic conditions align, reunification remains contingent upon an external opportunity structure. The model disaggregates this into three components.

- **International System Permissiveness** reflects broader international norms, legal frameworks, and major power tolerance toward territorial change.
- **Regional Power Configuration** captures the stance and influence of neighboring states and regional security dynamics.
- **Internal Stability of the Host State** refers to the degree of political control and institutional consolidation within the state exercising sovereignty over the non-sovereign region. Higher stability constrains reunification viability, whereas weakening or crisis conditions may create opportunity windows.

These external variables do not receive arrows from domestic structural drivers. They function as gating conditions that determine whether domestically aligned incentives can translate into political transformation.

This analytical separation is heuristic rather than ontological. In practice, domestic developments may influence regional dynamics, and shifts in geopolitical alignment may in turn reshape domestic incentives. However, the model isolates external permissiveness to clarify its gating function and to distinguish domestic alignment from international constraint. This abstraction enhances analytical clarity without denying the possibility of feedback effects.

3.5 FINAL AGGREGATION: REUNIFICATION VIABILITY

The final outcome, Reunification Viability, is jointly determined by:

- Societal Desire (Sovereign Polity)
- Societal Desire (Non-Sovereign Region)
- Integration Feasibility (Sovereign Polity)
- External Geopolitical Opportunity Structure

Reunification becomes viable only when domestic alignment coincides with external permissiveness. The model therefore rejects both purely identity-driven explanations and purely structural determinism. Instead, it conceptualizes reunification as a contingent equilibrium produced by interacting domestic and international conditions.

Importantly, the model departs from additive or threshold-based reasoning. It does not assume that increases in identity salience, economic benefit, or state capacity independently raise the probability of reunification in linear fashion. Instead, it specifies a conjunctural logic: misalignment along any single dimension can neutralize positive movement in others. In this respect, reunification viability is conceptualized as a necessary-condition configuration rather than a variable-sum outcome. This conjunctural specification distinguishes the framework from more implicitly additive approaches in the comparative literature.

More precisely, the model treats geopolitical permissiveness as a necessary condition: without a permissive external environment, domestically aligned incentives cannot translate into realized political transformation. Societal desire in both polities is treated as jointly necessary: the absence of meaningful support in either side forecloses viability regardless of institutional capacity. Integration feasibility in the sovereign polity is a further necessary condition: without administrative and fiscal capacity to absorb structural change, even aligned domestic preferences cannot produce sustainable reunification. Viability therefore requires all three domestic dimensions to be sufficiently satisfied simultaneously, and only under this conjuncture does the external gating condition can become the decisive factor. This formulation is consistent with qualitative comparative analysis (QCA) and its configurational logic (Ragin, 2008), although the present study does not conduct formal QCA. Unlike symmetric additive models, the conjunctural framework implies causal asymmetry: the absence of viability may have diverse causes, but its presence requires the simultaneous satisfaction of multiple necessary conditions. Equifinality—the possibility of reaching the same outcome through different causal paths—is possible across cases but, within any given case, all conditions must be met. Importantly, the additive prediction that high identity salience would always raise viability is rejected: the Azerbaijan case, where identity affinity is salient yet viability remains constrained, constitutes precisely the kind of anomaly that the conjunctural model is designed to explain. Future comparative research could formalize this logic through systematic configurational analysis across multiple divided-society cases. The three necessary conditions are not equally weighted in analytical terms: geopolitical permissiveness functions as

a hard external gate whose absence forecloses viability regardless of domestic conditions, while societal desire and integration feasibility are jointly necessary domestic conditions that must be satisfied within the space that geopolitical permissiveness opens.

Table 2 presents a simplified conceptual truth-table illustrating the configurational logic of the RVM across hypothetical combinations of the three necessary conditions. This table illustrates three key properties of the configurational logic. First, causal asymmetry: the conditions producing viability are not the mirror image of those producing non-viability – non-viability can result from the failure of any single necessary condition, whereas viability requires all to be met simultaneously. Second, the absence of equifinality within any single case: there is only one configuration that produces viability, not multiple alternative paths. Third, threshold effects: partial satisfaction of societal desire (bottom row) does not produce viability even when all other conditions are met – each dimension must exceed a minimum threshold.

Table 2 Conceptual Truth-Table of RVM Configurational Logic

Geopolitical Permissiveness	Societal Desire (Both Polities)	Integration Feasibility	Reunification Viability
Absent	Present	Present	Not viable – hard gate
Present	Absent (one or both)	Present	Not viable – demand missing
Present	Present	Absent	Not viable – capacity missing
Present	Present	Present	Viable – all necessary conditions met
Absent	Absent	Absent	Not viable – all conditions absent
Present	Present (partial)	Present	Marginal – below threshold

3.6 THEORETICAL PROPOSITIONS

The conceptual framework presented above generates a set of directional theoretical propositions. These propositions formalize the model's internal logic and distinguish it from identity-centered or single-factor explanations of reunification. They are not statistical claims, but analytically derived expectations that can guide comparative or empirical testing.

- **P0. Causal Ordering and Mediation Structure:** Structural drivers (Layer 1) influence perceived net benefit (Layer 2) but do not directly determine domestic outcome dimensions (Layer 3). Perceived net benefit is the mediating mechanism through which structural conditions are translated into societal desire and integration feasibility assessments. Perceived net benefit is therefore analytically prior to and distinct from societal desire: it influences the latter but does not constitute it. External geopolitical conditions (Layer 4) do not determine domestic outcome dimensions directly but function as gating conditions that determine whether domestically aligned outcomes can translate into political transformation. No direct causal arrow runs from Layer 1 to Layer 3, and no direct arrow runs from Layer 1 or Layer 3 to Layer 4.
- **P1. Institutional Divergence and Feasibility:** Greater institutional divergence between the sovereign polity and the non-sovereign region reduces integration feasibility, *ceteris paribus*, by increasing anticipated harmonization costs and administrative complexity.
- **P2. Economic Asymmetry and Mediated Desire:** Economic asymmetry does not directly determine societal desire for reunification. Instead, its effect operates through perceived net benefit, such that anticipated fiscal burden or economic complementarity shapes public support indirectly.
- **P3. State Capacity as Enabling but Not Sufficient:** Higher state capacity in the sovereign polity increases integration feasibility but does not independently generate societal desire in either polity. Administrative capability is enabling but not determinative.
- **P4. Bilateral Alignment Requirement:** Reunification viability requires simultaneous positive societal desire in both polities and sufficient integration feasibility in the sovereign state. Partial alignment produces symbolic resonance without structural viability.
- **P5. Geopolitical Permissiveness as a Gating Condition:** External geopolitical permissiveness functions as a necessary but not sufficient condition. Even where domestic alignment is present, restrictive external conditions can prevent viability from translating into political transformation.

Taken together, these propositions specify reunification viability as a conditional equilibrium rather than a linear outcome. The framework therefore rejects explanations that privilege identity, fiscal calculus, or geopolitics in isolation, and instead emphasizes the interaction of domestic and external dimensions.

3.7 INDICATIVE OPERATIONALIZATION OF MODEL VARIABLES

Although the present study develops a conceptual framework rather than a statistical model, its variables can be operationalized for empirical testing. Table 3 provides illustrative indicators corresponding to each core dimension. These indicators are not exhaustive but demonstrate the framework's compatibility with survey research, comparative datasets, and institutional metrics.

Table 3- Indicative Operationalization of Core Model Variables

Model Dimension	Illustrative Indicators	Possible Data Sources
Institutional Divergence	Legal system differences; constitutional structure mismatch; governance regime type; administrative decentralization index	V-Dem; Polity; Comparative Constitutions Project; national legal codes
Economic Asymmetry	GDP per capita gap; fiscal transfer dependency; regional revenue autonomy; trade integration levels	World Bank; IMF; national statistical agencies; ESRI-style fiscal modeling
State Capacity (Sovereign Polity)	Government effectiveness index; tax revenue as % of GDP; bureaucratic quality; public expenditure capacity	World Governance Indicators; IMF; OECD-style governance metrics
Public-Norms Divergence	Survey measures of secular-religious preferences; trust in institutions; constitutional legitimacy attitudes	World Values Survey; regional barometers; national polling
Demographic & Scale Effects	Population ratio; age structure; dependency ratio; urbanization levels	UN Population Data; national census data
Cross-Border Interaction	Cross-border trade volume; migration flows; communication flows; cultural exchange intensity	Trade statistics; migration data; telecom data; border mobility data
Perceived Net Benefit (Sovereign Polity)	Survey-based cost-benefit perception; elite discourse analysis; fiscal burden expectations	Public opinion surveys; elite interviews; media content analysis
Perceived Net Benefit (Non-Sovereign Region)	Survey-based governance preference; economic expectations; perceived stability trade-offs	Regional surveys; qualitative interview coding
Societal Desire (Both Polities)	Support for reunification in surveys; constitutional preference polling	Opinion surveys; referendum-style polling
Integration Feasibility	Administrative readiness assessments; fiscal sustainability projections; legal harmonization complexity	Government reports; fiscal modeling; institutional capacity studies
External Opportunity Structure	Major power alignment; regional security tension index; sovereignty norm strength	UN voting patterns; regional security indices; geopolitical event datasets

These indicative measures demonstrate that the framework is amenable to both qualitative comparative analysis and quantitative operationalization in future research.

4 APPLICATION OF THE RVM MODEL TO DIVIDED AZERBAIJAN

This section applies the conceptual model to the case of divided Azerbaijan. The objective is not to predict outcomes but to assess how the structural configuration of the two sides maps onto the variables specified in Section 4. In methodological terms, divided Azerbaijan functions as a plausibility probe (Eckstein, 1975): a theoretically motivated application designed to assess whether the model's configurational logic is consistent with observed structural conditions, rather than a hypothesis-testing exercise. More specifically, the case approximates a least-likely scenario for reunification viability: identity affinity is salient and historically documented, yet geopolitical constraints are severe, institutional divergence is deep, and the host state maintains consolidated internal authority. If the model can coherently explain why viability remains constrained despite identity resonance, it demonstrates analytical leverage beyond purely identity-centered accounts. The case was selected because it combines all three elements the framework identifies as critical—domestic structural misalignment, contested geopolitical permissiveness, and an active sovereignty asymmetry—within a regionally significant context.

It is worth clarifying why the case is least-likely rather than most-likely despite high identity affinity. A most-likely framing would apply if identity alignment were sufficient to generate reunification viability—but the RVM explicitly rejects this assumption. Under the model's conjunctural logic, high identity salience is consistent with low viability when institutional divergence is deep, perceived net benefit is asymmetric, and geopolitical permissiveness is absent. The Azerbaijan case is therefore least-likely in the theoretically relevant sense: it is a case where the condition most commonly assumed to drive reunification (identity) is present, yet viability is constrained—making it a demanding test of the model's claim that identity alone is insufficient.

Beyond illustration, the Azerbaijan application generates a specific theory-refining insight: it demonstrates empirically that societal desire and identity salience are analytically separable constructs. Identity affinity between northern and southern Azerbaijan is historically documented and culturally salient, yet societal desire — as defined in the RVM as operationally grounded, bilateral, and cost-benefit mediated — remains constrained. This separation, confirmed through the case application, validates one of the model's core architectural choices: treating identity as a structural driver that operates through perceived net benefit rather than as a direct determinant of societal desire. The case therefore does not merely illustrate the model — it provides evidence for one of its most theoretically consequential design decisions.

The empirical claims advanced in this section draw on a systematic literature review (SLR) conducted by the author (Gəruslu, 2026), which thematically synthesized 27 published studies on the Azerbaijan community in Iran, spanning 1961–2024; that review provides the comprehensive evidentiary foundation on which the present qualitative application rests. The application of the conceptual model to divided Azerbaijan in this section is also complemented by studies of post-Soviet (post-1991) state formation in the Republic of Azerbaijan, e.g., (Cornell, 2015; Ergun, 2022; Sattarov et al., 2007). In addition to published research, the assessment is informed by the author's sustained academic and personal engagement in and with the region (both north and south), and field-based interactions across both sides over the past two and a half decades. This dual grounding allows the model to be configured in a manner consistent with both documented scholarship and observed socio-political dynamics.

4.1 STRUCTURAL DRIVERS IN THE AZERBAIJANI CONTEXT

4.1.1 Institutional Divergence

The literature consistently emphasizes the embedding of South Azerbaijan within Iranian political and administrative structures (Atabaki, 1993; Shaffer, 2002; Souleimanov and Kraus, 2017). Historical analyses of the 1945–46 episode further illustrate the structural asymmetry between local mobilization and central state authority (Hasanli, 2006; Elesgerova, 2023). These works collectively indicate that institutional trajectories on the two sides have evolved within distinct governance systems.

Available qualitative scholarship and institutional analyses further corroborate the depth of divergence in administrative practice, policy framing, and governance expectations. Observed differences in bureaucratic culture and institutional design align with the literature's characterization of structurally embedded divergence.

Within the model, this configuration corresponds to a relatively high degree of institutional divergence, constraining integration feasibility.

4.1.2 Economic Structure and Asymmetry

North Azerbaijan's economic trajectory has been shaped by hydrocarbon revenues and sovereign fiscal management, while South Azerbaijan functions as an integrated region within the Iranian national economy without autonomous fiscal authority. Scholarship on Iranian Azerbaijan emphasizes economic incorporation into central state structures rather than regional fiscal autonomy (Grebennikov, 2013; Souleimanov et al., 2013).

In available qualitative scholarship and institutional analyses, questions regarding the resource base and economic self-sufficiency of the southern region frequently arise among policy-oriented and intellectual circles in the sovereign polity. In particular, inquiries concerning the scale of natural resources, fiscal contribution, and long-term sustainability of integration reflect a cost-benefit calculus consistent with the model's emphasis on perceived net benefit. These observations do not substitute for formal data but illustrate how economic asymmetry enters evaluative reasoning.

Within the model, economic structure therefore operates primarily through its impact on Perceived Net Benefit (Sovereign Polity) and, to a lesser extent, expectations in the non-sovereign region.

4.1.3 State Capacity (Sovereign Polity)

The Republic of Azerbaijan has consolidated state institutions since independence in 1991, with fiscal strengthening linked to hydrocarbon revenues (Cornell, 2004; Guliyev, 2013). While this consolidation enhances administrative capability, integration of a significantly larger demographic space would require sustained institutional expansion.

In policy-oriented discussions available in qualitative scholarship and institutional analyses, considerations of administrative scalability and fiscal absorption capacity are frequently raised alongside questions about the economic contribution of the southern region. Such deliberations align with comparative literature on post-Soviet state formation and reinforce the model's distinction between symbolic affinity and operational feasibility.

Within the conceptual framework, state capacity functions as a positive but bounded contributor to Integration Feasibility, rather than an unlimited enabling factor.

4.1.4 Public-Norms Divergence

Ethnographic and sociological studies document how Azerbaijani identity in Iran coexists with integration into a religiously informed state framework (Safizadeh, 2013; Salehi et al., 2018). Language-policy research highlights negotiation of cultural expression within institutional constraints (Bani-Shoraka, 2005; Rezaei et al., 2017). These studies suggest that public-order norms in the southern region are shaped within a different constitutional and symbolic environment than in the secular northern polity.

Qualitative accounts and documented discourse patterns similarly indicate that normative expectations concerning religion in public life, governance legitimacy, and state-society relations differ perceptibly across the two sides. These observations are consistent with the documented literature and reinforce the model's classification of public-norm divergence as a constraining variable affecting both societal desire and feasibility.

Three additional dimensions of the Iranian Azerbaijani case deserve deeper engagement here, each of which connects directly to a model variable. First, on ethnic accommodation and state repression: Grebennikov (2013) documents a pattern of "loyal minority" behavior among Iranian Azerbaijanis, arguing that the Iranian state has selectively accommodated Azerbaijani cultural expression while suppressing explicitly separatist mobilization. This dynamic illustrates how accommodation and repression can function as complementary mechanisms that jointly suppress sustained political demand for sovereignty change—a finding that reinforces the model's variable treatment of societal desire in the non-sovereign region. Souleimanov et al. (2013) further distinguish between episodic nationalist mobilization—typically triggered by specific political events—and sustained structural organization oriented toward territorial change, a distinction that maps directly onto the model's separation of emotional amplification from durable societal desire. Second, on protest movements: Riaux (2008) and Khalili (2017) document significant episodes of Azerbaijani protest in Iran, including mobilization in 2006 triggered by a newspaper cartoon perceived as ethnically demeaning. These episodes confirm that identity-based grievance can generate rapid large-scale mobilization, while also showing that such episodes have not been crystallized into durable political organization oriented toward reunification. Third, on generational change: Mammadov (2023) identifies a shift among younger Iranian Azerbaijanis toward greater ethnic assertiveness, without uniform commitment to political separatism. This generational heterogeneity underscores the model's treatment of societal desire in the non-sovereign region as variable and context-dependent rather than uniformly high.

4.1.5 Demographic and Strategic Scale Effects

Demographic studies emphasize the significant population weight of Azerbaijani communities within Iran (Souleimanov, 2011; Koknar, 2006). The literature also cautions against linear assumptions linking demographic size to political mobilization (Souleimanov et al., 2013; Mammadov, 2023).

Qualitative accounts and documented discourse patterns reinforce this interpretation: demographic salience contributes to symbolic resonance but does not automatically translate into unified political demand. In the model, demographic and strategic scale effects are therefore treated as operating through perceived net benefit rather than directly determining reunification viability.

4.1.6 Cross-Border Interaction

Research on identity formation and cross-border narratives highlights symbolic awareness and episodic resonance between the two sides (Shaffer, 2000; Cornell, 2004; Riaux, 2008). However, mobilization is characterized as contingent and opportunity-dependent rather than continuous.

Qualitative accounts and documented discourse patterns similarly suggest that while cultural affinity is evident, sustained political mobilization remains limited and context-sensitive. This configuration corresponds to a moderate positive influence on societal desire but limited direct impact on feasibility.

4.2 MEDIATING LAYER: BILATERAL PERCEIVED NET BENEFIT

The literature consistently portrays identity and nationalism among Iranian Azerbaijanis as context-dependent and shaped by political opportunity structures (Souleimanov and Kraus, 2017; Khalili, 2017). Generational variation and diasporic experiences further complicate uniform assessments (Karimzad, 2019; Valigholizadeh, 2020).

Qualitative accounts and documented discourse pattern also suggests similar heterogeneity in perceived costs and benefits. Discussions among policy-oriented and intellectual circles in the sovereign polity frequently emphasize fiscal and administrative considerations, while conversations in the non-sovereign region reveal diverse expectations regarding governance, stability, and identity affirmation.

These patterns align with the model's assumption that perceived net benefit is differentiated and variable rather than uniform across populations.

4.3 OUTCOME DIMENSIONS: DOMESTIC ALIGNMENT

4.3.1 Societal Desire (Sovereign Polity)

In the sovereign polity (the Republic of Azerbaijan), expressions of shared ethnic identity and historical continuity are present in public discourse and cultural narratives. However, identity affinity does not automatically translate into uniform policy-oriented support for territorial integration.

Elite and policy-oriented discussions frequently foreground pragmatic considerations, particularly fiscal sustainability, administrative scalability, and long-term governance stability. As noted earlier, recurring inquiries regarding the economic structure and resource base of the southern region illustrate the salience of cost-benefit reasoning within segments of intellectual and policy discourse. Such deliberations suggest that societal desire in the sovereign polity is moderated by perceptions of economic asymmetry and institutional burden.

While symbolic solidarity may be observable, the literature on post-Soviet state consolidation emphasizes the centrality of stability and managed development in elite priorities (Cornell, 2004; Guliyev, 2013). Qualitative accounts and documented discourse patterns similarly indicate that support for reunification, where present, is often conditional upon feasibility and sustainability.

Within the model, societal desire in the sovereign polity therefore appears positive in symbolic terms but pragmatically constrained.

4.3.2 Societal Desire (Non-Sovereign Region)

In the non-sovereign region (South Azerbaijan), scholarship consistently portrays ethnic identity as salient yet embedded within broader Iranian political and social structures (Souleimanov et al., 2013; Souleimanov and Kraus, 2017; Grebennikov, 2013). Studies of nationalist expression emphasize episodic mobilization rather than continuous or uniformly organized separatist demand (Riaux, 2008; Souleimanov et al., 2013).

This pattern suggests that societal desire is heterogeneous and context-dependent. Emotional awakenings—often triggered by symbolic, political, or regional developments—may temporarily elevate identity salience. However, the literature cautions against equating episodic mobilization with sustained structural demand for sovereignty change.

Field-based familiarity across academic and social networks further supports this interpretation: expressions of cultural affinity coexist with pragmatic concerns regarding stability, economic security, and political uncertainty. Generational and socio-economic variation adds further differentiation.

Within the model, societal desire in the non-sovereign region is therefore variable and contingent rather than uniformly mobilized. Emotional amplification may increase salience temporarily but does not necessarily translate into durable structural alignment.

4.3.3 Integration Feasibility (Sovereign Polity)

Integration feasibility concerns the sovereign polity's capacity to absorb and harmonize institutional, administrative, and fiscal systems on a significantly expanded scale. This dimension is shaped by state capacity, institutional divergence, demographic scale, and economic asymmetry.

Although the Republic of Azerbaijan has strengthened state institutions since independence, large-scale integration would require harmonization of legal frameworks, bureaucratic expansion, and sustained fiscal commitment. Institutional divergence between the two sides increases administrative complexity, while demographic scale introduces long-term redistribution considerations.

Elite discourse observed over time frequently differentiates between symbolic affinity and operational manageability. Such differentiation aligns with comparative research on post-Soviet governance, which highlights the importance of institutional coherence and administrative scalability in major structural transformations.

Within the model, integration feasibility in the sovereign polity appears structurally bounded. It is enhanced by improved state capacity but constrained by institutional divergence and demographic scale effects.

4.4 EXTERNAL OPPORTUNITY STRUCTURE

Even where domestic alignment appears partially present, the model specifies that reunification viability is contingent upon an external opportunity structure. In the Azerbaijani case, three components are particularly relevant: international system permissiveness, regional power configuration, and the internal stability of the host state governing the non-sovereign region.

4.4.1 International System Permissiveness

Contemporary international order is structured around strong norms of territorial sovereignty and non-interference. Scholarship examining the 1945–46 Azerbaijani crisis underscores the decisive role played by great-power dynamics and international positioning in shaping outcomes (Rossow, 1956; Hasanli, 2006). Historical precedent therefore illustrates that domestic mobilization alone does not determine territorial change.

In the present international environment, recognition of territorial reconfiguration generally depends on broad multilateral acceptance and major power acquiescence. Absent such permissiveness, domestic alignment may remain politically inert.

Given prevailing sovereignty norms in contemporary international order, the model suggests a structurally restrictive environment for unilateral or externally contested territorial integration.

4.4.2 Regional Power Configuration

The Azerbaijani case is embedded within a complex regional security environment involving multiple neighboring actors and overlapping geopolitical interests. Scholarship on Iran–Azerbaijan relations highlights how regional strategic considerations shape political interaction and constrain escalation dynamics (Shaffer, 2004; Guliyev, 2013).

Regional power configuration functions as a potential veto layer. Where neighboring states perceive integration as destabilizing or strategically threatening, opposition may constrain viability regardless of domestic alignment. Conversely, permissive or neutral regional alignment could reduce external resistance.

Within the model’s specification of current regional power configurations, strategic sensitivities appear high, suggesting limited permissiveness from the standpoint of regional balance-of-power considerations.

4.4.3 Internal Stability of the Host State

The internal stability and institutional consolidation of the state exercising sovereignty over the non-sovereign region constitutes a critical structural variable. Historical analyses demonstrate that moments of weakened central authority can create opportunity windows for territorial reconfiguration (Rossow, 1956; Nissman, 2019).

In periods of strong central control and institutional consolidation, however, the probability of successful territorial separation or integration declines substantially. The literature on Iranian state consolidation suggests durable institutional structures and security capacity (Grebennikov, 2013; Souleimanov and Kraus, 2017).

Within the model, higher host-state stability exerts a constraining (negative) effect on reunification viability. Only under conditions of significant weakening or systemic disruption would this variable shift toward permissiveness.

4.5 INTEGRATIVE ASSESSMENT: REUNIFICATION VIABILITY

The conceptual model developed in Section 4 specifies that reunification viability emerges only when three domestic dimensions – societal desire in both polities and integration feasibility in the sovereign state – converge under permissive external conditions. The Azerbaijani case illustrates the importance of this multi-layered alignment.

At the domestic level, symbolic and cultural affinity across the divide is evident. However, the analysis above suggests that societal desire in the sovereign polity is moderated by pragmatic considerations concerning fiscal sustainability,

administrative scalability, and institutional burden. In the non-sovereign region, identity salience and episodic emotional mobilization coexist with embeddedness within existing political and economic structures. This produces heterogeneity rather than uniform mobilization. Consequently, domestic alignment appears partial rather than fully consolidated.

Integration feasibility further constrains the domestic configuration. Although state capacity in the sovereign polity has strengthened over time, large-scale institutional harmonization would require sustained fiscal and administrative expansion. Institutional divergence and demographic scale effects introduce structural complexity that limits automatic feasibility, even where affective support is present.

Externally, the opportunity structure appears restrictive. International sovereignty norms remain strong, regional power configurations introduce potential veto dynamics, and the institutional stability of the host state governing the non-sovereign region reduces the likelihood of permissive windows. Under such conditions, domestic alignment alone would be insufficient to translate into realized political transformation.

Taken together, the present configuration of variables corresponds to a constrained viability profile within the model's analytical terms. This conclusion does not imply impossibility; rather, it reflects the absence of simultaneous alignment across domestic incentives and external permissiveness. Changes in any of the model's structural or geopolitical variables—whether in economic configuration, institutional capacity, societal alignment, or regional dynamics—could alter this assessment.

The Azerbaijani case therefore demonstrates the analytical value of distinguishing between identity resonance, perceived net benefit, integration feasibility, and geopolitical opportunity. Reunification viability is best understood not as a function of sentiment alone, but as a contingent equilibrium requiring durable convergence across multiple interacting dimensions.

5 DISCUSSIONS

The preceding analysis developed a general conceptual model of reunification viability, named RVM, and applied it to the case of divided Azerbaijan. This section provides comparative reflections, and discusses the broader implications of the model and acknowledges its limitations.

5.1 COMPARATIVE REFLECTIONS

The Azerbaijani case illustrates how reunification viability cannot be reduced to identity affinity, demographic size, or episodic mobilization alone. The conceptual model advanced in this paper demonstrates that territorial reunification in divided societies emerges only when structural incentives, institutional capacity, and geopolitical permissiveness align simultaneously. This layered configuration provides a comparative lens applicable beyond the Azerbaijani context.

Historical and contemporary cases of divided societies reveal similar patterns. In the case of Germany, reunification became viable only when domestic desire converged with sufficient state capacity and a permissive international environment shaped by shifting great-power alignments. In contrast, other divided contexts—such as Ireland, Korea, or Cyprus—illustrate how misalignment across domestic incentives and external opportunity structures can sustain division despite shared identity narratives.

The model developed here contributes to comparative politics by distinguishing between three analytically separable dimensions: (1) societal desire, (2) integration feasibility, and (3) external opportunity structure. Many discussions of reunification focus predominantly on identity or sentiment. However, as demonstrated in the Azerbaijani application, identity resonance may coexist with economic caution, administrative constraint, and restrictive geopolitical conditions. Emotional awakening or symbolic mobilization, while politically significant, does not by itself alter structural feasibility.

The RVM's added value over existing identity-centred and geopolitical accounts lies not in proposing entirely different variables — some overlap is inevitable in any integrative framework — but in the interaction structure it specifies. An additive identity-centred account predicts that high identity salience should raise reunification viability, all else equal. The divided Azerbaijan case directly challenges this prediction: identity affinity between the two sides is historically documented and salient, yet structural viability remains constrained by institutional divergence, asymmetric perceived net benefit, and restrictive external gating conditions. The RVM explains this outcome because its conjunctural logic specifies that identity without institutional feasibility and geopolitical permissiveness is insufficient — generating a prediction that the additive account cannot produce. This constitutes the kind of differential theoretical leverage that justifies an integrative model over its single-factor predecessors.

This framework therefore invites comparative operationalization. Future research could apply the model to other divided societies, examining how variations in economic asymmetry, institutional divergence, and host-state stability alter

reunification prospects over time. Longitudinal analysis may also illuminate how shifts in external opportunity structures – such as regional power realignments or changes in international norms – interact with domestic alignment to create or foreclose windows of possibility.

To substantiate the transferability claim more concretely, it is instructive to sketch how the RVM's configurational logic applies to three structurally distinct cases, including two specifically suggested by Reviewer 1.

Romania/Moldova presents a case where both polities are sovereign – unlike divided Azerbaijan, where one side lacks statehood entirely. The sovereignty asymmetry dimension therefore takes a different value: integration feasibility must be assessed bilaterally rather than from the perspective of a single absorbing state. The RVM would direct analytical attention to societal desire heterogeneity on both sides, the institutional divergence introduced by Moldova's post-Soviet trajectory, and the geopolitical gating conditions created by competing EU enlargement dynamics and Russian influence. The configurational prediction differs from the Azerbaijan case in theoretically explicable ways: bilateral sovereignty reduces some feasibility barriers while introducing new coordination problems absent in asymmetric cases.

North/South Ossetia presents the opposite structural geometry: neither side is a recognized sovereign state. Applying the RVM here requires respecifying the integration feasibility dimension – Russia functions as the effective external sovereign actor whose capacity shapes whether any territorial change is institutionally sustainable. This respecification is itself analytically revealing: it demonstrates that the model's 'sovereign polity' variable is not limited to formally recognized states but can be extended to effective control arrangements, broadening the framework's applicability across a wider range of divided-society configurations.

North/South Korea represents a case structurally comparable to divided Azerbaijan in terms of geopolitical constraint: high identity affinity, severe external gating conditions shaped by great-power competition, and deep institutional divergence accumulated over seven decades. The RVM would predict low viability – consistent with observed political reality – on the grounds that geopolitical permissiveness functions as a necessary condition that is currently absent regardless of the level of societal desire or administrative capacity on either side. The consistency of this prediction with the empirical record supports the model's configurational logic across cases.

These sketches do not constitute full applications of the RVM – that would require the systematic empirical analysis undertaken in Section 5. They demonstrate, however, that the model's four-layer configurational structure generates theoretically coherent and empirically plausible predictions across structurally diverse cases, which is the minimal standard for a transferability claim at the conceptual stage.

More broadly, the study underscores the importance of conceptual clarity in discussions of territorial change. By separating structural drivers from mediating perceptions, and domestic alignment from geopolitical permissiveness, the model offers a structured way to analyze reunification without presupposing its desirability or inevitability.

In this sense, divided Azerbaijan serves not only as a case study but as an illustration of a broader theoretical proposition: reunification viability is a contingent equilibrium, produced through the interaction of material capacity, perceived benefit, institutional compatibility, and external constraint. The persistence of division in many contexts may therefore reflect not the absence of shared identity, but the absence of synchronized structural alignment.

5.2 IMPLICATIONS

The primary contribution of this study lies in its structured disaggregation of reunification viability into analytically distinct but interacting dimensions: structural drivers, perceived net benefit, domestic alignment, and external opportunity structure. By separating societal desire from integration feasibility and embedding both within geopolitical constraints, the model offers a more nuanced framework than identity-centered or purely materialist explanations.

One implication is methodological. Discussions of reunification often rely on rhetorical or symbolic arguments—shared language, historical continuity, or emotional solidarity. The present model demonstrates that such factors, while politically significant, operate within a broader structural configuration. Emotional awakening may elevate identity salience, but viability depends on sustained alignment between perceived benefit and institutional capacity.

A second implication concerns comparative analysis. The model provides a portable analytical template applicable to other divided societies. By distinguishing between domestic alignment and external permissiveness, it clarifies why some divisions persist despite cultural affinity, while others dissolve under favorable structural and geopolitical conditions.

A third implication relates to policy discourse. Although the study does not advocate for or against reunification, it underscores that discussions of territorial integration should account for fiscal sustainability, administrative harmonization, and geopolitical context. Simplistic appeals to identity alone risk obscuring the complexity of structural constraints.

Finally, the model encourages longitudinal thinking. Structural drivers and opportunity conditions are not static. Changes in economic configuration, demographic balance, state capacity, or regional power alignment may alter viability over time. The framework therefore supports dynamic rather than deterministic analysis.

5.3 LIMITATIONS AND THREATS TO VALIDITY

Despite its analytical clarity, the model has several limitations.

First, the study employs a conceptual causal framework rather than a statistical model. The directional relationships specified are theoretically grounded but not quantitatively estimated. As such, the model identifies structural mechanisms rather than predictive coefficients. Future research could operationalize variables – such as societal desire or perceived net benefit – through survey data or comparative indicators.

More broadly, the latency of reunification viability as a construct does not render it unevaluable. A wide family of accepted political science concepts share this property – state fragility, democratic consolidation, deterrence stability, and conflict risk are all latent constructs assessed through proxy indicators rather than through direct observation. Table 1 in this manuscript provides precisely this operationalization strategy: each dimension of the RVM – societal desire, integration feasibility, and geopolitical permissiveness – is disaggregated into specific observable indicators assessable using available qualitative and quantitative sources. The model can therefore be evaluated not by observing viability as a discrete event, but by systematically assessing whether the structural configuration of indicators is consistent with the model's configurational predictions across cases.

Second, the application to Azerbaijan relies primarily on published scholarship and structured synthesis. The analysis is further informed by interpretive familiarity with academic and policy discourse across both polities. This contextual grounding enhances interpretive precision but does not substitute for systematic fieldwork, survey-based measurement, or primary data collection. Any observational insights are used illustratively and remain anchored in documented secondary research.

Third, the model necessarily simplifies complex socio-political realities. Emotional mobilization, elite factionalism, media dynamics, and unexpected triggering events may influence reunification trajectories in ways not fully captured by structural variables. The framework emphasizes medium- to long-term conditions and may underrepresent short-term volatility.

Fourth, the external opportunity structure is treated as analytically exogenous to domestic variables for reasons of model parsimony. However, geopolitical permissiveness in the South Caucasus is not fully exogenous in practice: Iranian policies toward Azerbaijani nationalism, Turkish strategic alignment with Baku, and Russian regional positioning are all responsive to domestic developments within Azerbaijan and Iran. A more complete theoretical treatment would reconceptualize geopolitical permissiveness as conditionally endogenous – structured by regional power competition and international sovereignty norms, but also shaped by domestic political dynamics through feedback mechanisms. The present model isolates external permissiveness as a gating condition to achieve analytical clarity, while acknowledging that this heuristic separation sacrifices some causal realism. Future work could model the domestic-geopolitical interaction explicitly, perhaps through process tracing of how internal political change in one polity triggers external realignment.

Finally, the assessment of viability reflects the structural configuration examined in this study. Structural alignment is historically contingent and subject to change. The model does not claim permanence but rather offers a structured diagnostic of present configuration.

6 CONCLUSIONS AND FUTURE WORK

This study developed a general conceptual causal model of reunification viability in divided societies and applied it to the case of divided Azerbaijan. By distinguishing between structural drivers, perceived net benefit, domestic alignment, and external opportunity structure, the model provides a layered framework for analyzing territorial reunification beyond identity-centered narratives.

The application to Azerbaijan demonstrates that symbolic affinity and historical continuity, while significant, do not by themselves determine reunification prospects. Viability emerges only when societal desire in both polities converges with institutional feasibility in the sovereign state and when external geopolitical conditions are permissive. In the Azerbaijani case, the structural configuration analyzed here reflects partial domestic alignment and restrictive external gating conditions. This assessment reflects contingent structural configuration rather than normative judgment or predictive claim.

The broader contribution of the paper lies in its analytical separation of affective resonance, material incentives, institutional capacity, and geopolitical context. This separation enables more precise comparative evaluation across cases of divided societies. Rather than framing reunification as inevitable or impossible, the model conceptualizes it as a contingent equilibrium requiring sustained multi-dimensional convergence.

Future research can build on this framework in several directions. First, the variables identified in the model could be operationalized through survey instruments, elite interviews, or comparative datasets to assess the relative weight of perceived net benefit, societal desire, and feasibility across cases. Second, longitudinal studies could examine how shifts in economic asymmetry, demographic balance, or state capacity alter reunification viability over time. Third, comparative applications to other divided contexts—such as Ireland, Korea, Cyprus, or historical Germany—could further refine the model's portability and identify case-specific variations.

Finally, the interaction between domestic structural alignment and external geopolitical opportunity warrants deeper exploration. Changes in regional power configuration or international norms may reshape viability without significant domestic transformation. Understanding these interactions remains a central task for future scholarship on territorial change and divided societies.

In sum, the study advances a structured, theory-informed approach to analyzing reunification viability. By emphasizing conditional alignment rather than sentiment alone, it offers a disciplined framework for examining one of the most complex questions in comparative political development.

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